Cup1 Phase 3 – Brand Strategy & Identity

B2B custom food-service packaging for the USA and Canada · Eco + compliant positioning

5 November 2026

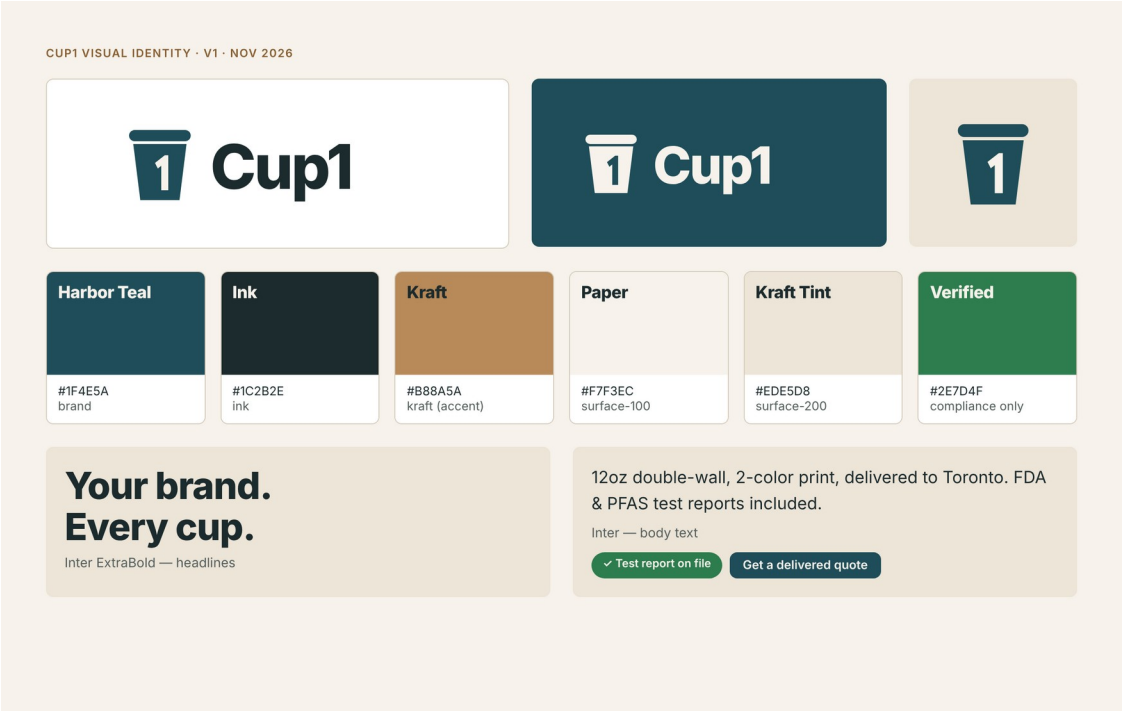
Brand positioning

Cup1 is the factory-direct packaging partner that gives North American cafés their own branded cups, with the compliance paperwork already done.

- **For:** independent café groups, bubble-tea and dessert chains, and regional distributors in the USA and Canada that order 30,000+ cups at a time.
- **Category:** custom-printed food-service packaging, covering cups, lids, bowls and boxes.
- **Why Cup1 wins:** buyers get factory pricing without importing alone. Every order comes with the FDA food-contact and PFAS-free test reports, and Vietnam production keeps duties low.
- **Proof we can show today:** our partner factory's BRC, BPI and FSC certificates, plus the FDA and PFAS test reports requested in the Phase 2 RFQ once they are received and checked. Cup1 has no client case studies yet, so the brand avoids claims like "trusted by hundreds of cafés" until they are true.

The company name stays **Cup1**. It is short and easy to remember, and the tagline does the explaining.

Visual identity



Cup1 visual identity – logo, colors, type

- **Logo:** a tapered cup with a "1" knocked out, plus the "Cup1" wordmark in Inter ExtraBold. There are three versions: horizontal, reversed and mark-only (SVG files are in the folder). Have a designer convert the wordmark to outlines before printing on physical goods.

- **Colors:** Harbor Teal #1F4E5A (brand), Ink #1C2B2E, Kraft #B88A5A (accent, never for text), Paper #F7F3EC (background), Kraft Tint #EDE5D8 (cards). Verified green #2E7D4F is used **only** for compliance proof. All text colors pass WCAG AA contrast (4.5:1 or better).
- **Type:** Inter (free on Google Fonts). ExtraBold for headlines, Regular and SemiBold for text.
- **Imagery:** real product photos from our samples. No stock eco clichés such as leaves, globes or seedlings.
- The full design system (tokens, usage rules, dark theme) lives in the **Cup1 Design System** artifact for the Phase 4 website build.

Competitor landscape

US competitors split into two camps: “fast and low-minimum” or “sustainable but slow”. None of them leads with compliance paperwork plus factory pricing, and that is the gap Cup1 takes.

Brand	Lead message	Minimum	Price / lead time seen	Eco angle
YourBrandCafe	“Branding Made Simple”, fast turn times, free shipping	1 case (500 cups)	12oz DW ≈ $0.38–0.50/cup; ~3 weeks	Compostable range, $1/case to charity: water
Good Start Packaging	“Sustainable Materials. Low Minimums. Fast production.”	50 cases (50,000 cups)	12oz compostable ≈ $0.11/cup; 14–16 weeks	PLA lining, FSC, no added PFAS, B Corp
noissue	Custom packaging that’s “sustainable & eco-friendly”	Not stated	Not stated	Sustainability is the whole brand
LogoCup	Custom cups for any occasion	50 cups	Event / small-run pricing	Not central

Where Cup1 sits: large-run pricing close to Good Start’s, faster production (about 35 days plus shipping), and a full set of compliance documents with every order. Cup1 does not compete on very small orders.

Target buyers

	1. Café group owner	2. Operations / procurement manager	3. Packaging distributor
Who	Owner of 3–30 cafés, bubble-tea or dessert shops	Buys supplies for a chain, university or caterer	Regional food-service distributor
Wants	Cups that look like *their* brand at a lower cost per cup	Reliable supply, compliant paperwork, one vendor	Private-label stock at factory prices, by the container
Fears	Ordering from overseas alone; wrong colors; late delivery	Failing a PFAS or compostable-labeling audit	Quality swings between batches; tariff surprises
Cup1 answer	Proofs and samples before paying the balance; delivered price up front	FDA / PFAS / BPI reports on file; reorder schedule	Vietnam-origin production, inspection report each shipment
First message	“Your logo on every cup, at factory-direct prices”	“Compliant packaging, documented, delivered”	“Factory-direct private label, lower duty than China”

The first sales effort goes to buyer 1.

Messaging

Value proposition: Your brand on every cup. Factory-direct prices, with food-safety and PFAS-free paperwork included, delivered to your door in the USA or Canada.

Three message pillars

1. **Your brand, everywhere it's carried.** Custom-printed cups, lids, bowls and boxes in one consistent look.
2. **Compliance, documented.** Every order ships with FDA food-contact and PFAS-free test reports. We only call products compostable when they are third-party certified.
3. **Factory-direct, landed.** Large-run pricing from certified factories, quoted as a delivered price with no surprise duties or freight.

Tagline options (recommended first)

- **Cup1 — Your brand. Every cup. Fully documented.**
- Cup1 — Branded packaging, done right.
- Cup1 — Factory-direct cups for growing cafés.

Elevator pitch (20 seconds)

> Cup1 puts your logo on cups, bowls and takeaway boxes at factory prices. We work directly with certified packaging factories, handle printing, inspection, shipping and customs, and deliver to your door in the US or Canada. Every order comes with food-safety and PFAS-free test reports, so you're covered on compliance.

Boilerplate

> Cup1 is a custom food-service packaging company serving cafés, restaurants and distributors across the United States and Canada. Cup1 sources custom-printed cups, bowls and boxes from certified manufacturing partners and manages quality control, logistics and compliance documentation from proof to delivery.

Brand voice

Cup1 sounds like a reliable operations partner: clear, practical and quietly confident.

Trait	We say	We avoid
Clear	"12oz double-wall, 2-color print, delivered to Toronto for $0.17/cup."	"Amazing premium solutions for your brand journey!"
Proof-led	"Test report attached."	"100% safe, totally green, planet-friendly."
Helpful	"Here's what your artwork needs to print sharply."	Jargon without explanation
Steady	"Production takes about 35 days; we'll update you weekly."	Overpromising speed

Write in American English. Prices are in USD unless the client asks for CAD.

Claims guardrails

The eco + compliant positioning only works if every claim can be proven. In the US and Canada, a vague green claim is a legal risk.

Claim	Allowed?	Condition
"FDA-compliant food-contact materials"	Yes	Only with a current lab test report for that product and supplier
"No intentionally added PFAS"	Yes	Supplier declaration + PFAS (total organic fluorine) test report on file
"Compostable"	Only if certified	Third-party certified (e.g. BPI); say "commercially compostable – facilities may not exist in your area"; check state

Claim	Allowed?	Condition
		labeling rules before printing it on cups
“Recyclable”	Avoid	PE-lined cups are not accepted in most curbside programs; California SB 343 limits recyclability claims (enforcement paused by court injunction since 14 Jul 2026)
“FSC-certified paper”	Yes	Only when produced under the factory’s FSC chain-of-custody
“Eco-friendly”, “green”, “sustainable” with no detail	No	FTC Green Guides treat broad unqualified claims as deceptive; Canada’s Competition Act requires substantiation
“Trusted by X cafés”, reviews, client logos	Not yet	Only with real clients who agree to be named

Rule of thumb: if we can’t attach the document, we don’t make the claim.

Product descriptions

The launch range is six products from Sowinpak’s catalogue. Bracketed specs must be confirmed against samples before publishing.

1. Double-Wall Hot Cup — 8 / 12 / 16 oz *(hero product)* Two layers of paperboard keep coffee hot and hands comfortable, with no sleeve needed. Printed edge-to-edge with your logo and colors, and paired with snug-fit lids. Food-safe lining, with FDA and PFAS test reports included. Minimum 30,000 cups per design.

2. Single-Wall Hot Cup — 4 to 20 oz The everyday workhorse for espresso, tea and drip coffee. Lightweight and stackable, printed in your brand colors. Add a custom sleeve for extra-hot drinks. [Paper weight: confirm GSM.]

3. Ripple-Wall Cup — 8 / 12 / 16 oz A textured outer wrap gives grip and insulation, with a premium feel in the hand. Ideal for specialty coffee shops that want their cup to stand out.

4. Ice Cream & Dessert Cups — 3 to 12 oz, with lids Sturdy, leak-resistant cups for gelato, frozen yogurt and puddings, printed inside and out. [Freezer performance: confirm with a sample test.]

5. Kraft Salad & Food Bowls — round and rectangular Grease-resistant kraft bowls for salads, poke and hot meals, with matching lids for delivery.

6. Takeaway Food Boxes — lunch, bakery window and pizza boxes Compartment lunch boxes, window boxes for pastries and cakes, and corrugated pizza boxes, all printed with your brand.

Sample kit concept

The **Cup1 Sample Kit** is the main sales tool. It is sent to qualified prospects after a first call.

- **Box:** kraft mailer (about 30 × 22 × 12 cm) with a one-color Cup1 logo and “Your brand. Every cup.” inside the lid
- **Inside:** 8 / 12 / 16 oz double-wall cups, a ripple cup, an ice-cream cup with lid and a kraft bowl, held in a die-cut insert
- **Print card:** a “How we print your logo” guide, a price sheet for 30k / 50k / 100k, and a QR code to the compliance-documents page
- **Personal touch:** where possible, one cup proof-printed with the prospect’s own logo
- **Estimated cost:** about $15–25 per kit plus courier (an assumption; get a quote for the mailer boxes with the first sample order)

Creative brief for Phase 4 (website)

Item	Brief
Goal	Turn café owners and buyers into quote and sample-kit requests
Primary action	“Get a delivered quote” form (product, size, quantity, city, logo upload)
Secondary action	“Request a sample kit” (qualified leads)
Key pages	Home · Products · How it works · Compliance documents · Pricing guide · About · Contact
Hero message	“Your brand. Every cup. Fully documented.”
Look and feel	Cup1 design system: Paper background, Harbor Teal, Inter, real sample photos
Must avoid	Unqualified green claims, fake reviews or client logos, stock photos shown as our product
Proof elements	Partner factory certificates, sample test reports, a process timeline

Sources

- YourBrandCafe – https://www.yourbrandcafe.com/
- Good Start Packaging 12oz compostable cup – https://www.goodstartpackaging.com/12-oz-custom-printed-compostable-white-paper-coffee-cups/
- noissue cups – https://noissue.co/category/cafe-cups-and-sleeves
- LogoCup (Fresh Cup) – https://freshcup.com/with-a-50-cup-minimum-logocup-makes-custom-cups-doable-for-any-occasion/
- California SB 343 injunction (DWT, Jul 2026) – https://www.dwt.com/blogs/energy–environmental-law-blog/2026/07/sb-343-truth-in-recycling-injunction
- Canada Competition Act greenwashing amendments (Mondaq) – https://www.mondaq.com/canada/environmental-law/1768676/legislation-passes-to-amend-environmental-claims-prohibitions-of-the-competition-act
- Green Guides and state compostable claims (Packaging Dive) – https://www.packagingdive.com/news/green-guides-recyclable-compostable-marketing-claims-states/650733